Validation Exercise

Each partner chooses one or two stems daily (or after a disagreement).
Speak slowly. Make eye contact. Keep your tone gentle.

1. "I can understand why you felt _____ when _____."
2. "It makes sense that you would feel _____ because _____."
3. "Hearing that, I realize you needed me to _____."
4. "If I were in your shoes, I might have felt _____ too."
5. "When that happened, it must have felt like _____."
6. "I didn't notice it in the moment, but I see now that _____."
7. "Thank you for helping me understand how that affected you."
8. "I hear that this situation made you feel _____."
9. "I'm sorry for missing that, I understand why that hurt."
10. "Your feelings matter to me, even when I don't fully understand them yet."

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How To Validate Your Partner's Feelings

1. Acknowledge what they're feeling.
2. Make space for their emotions.
3. Let them know their feelings make sense.
4. Show empathy and understanding.
5. Mirror what you hear without judgment.
6. Communicate that their emotions are real and important.
7. Respond with compassion instead of correction.
8. Reflect their emotional experience back to them.
9. Let them know you "get it" before you "fix it."
10. Meet them where they are emotionally.

10 Validation Statements for Couples to Practice

1. "I can understand why you feel that way."
2. "That makes sense given what you've been through."
3. "I didn't realize it affected you like that, thank you for telling me."
4. "If I were in your shoes, I might feel the same way."
5. "You have every right to feel hurt/disappointed/angry."
6. "I hear you saying that you felt dismissed and unimportant, is that right?"
7. "I can see that this really matters to you."
8. "It sounds like that moment was really painful for you."
9. "I didn't mean to cause that pain, but I understand why it hurt."
10. "Your feelings are valid, I'm here to listen, not argue."

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